meet your neighbors By Resident **Suzie Rankins**, Founder and President of Bless This Home

The hearts and muscles behind Bless This Home

L. to R.: The Bless This Home Board Members Dana Oelkers, Alex Lominy, Suzie Rankins, Ginger Munson, Taryn Lennon, and Jeanne Mellish

L. To R.: Ryan Rankins, Nolan Arnold, Caden Brown, Noah Riley

With so many needs in this world, it can sometimes leave a person wondering, "What can I do to help, or what do I even have to offer?" That question was answered eight years ago in a meaningful way for one Bedford woman. A social worker at Elliot Hospital asked our founder, Suzie Rankins, if she and her husband could help obtain beds and a few essentials for a homeless family, a young mother with four children. Within two weeks, and just by reaching out to a few friends in the Bedford area, she was able to fully furnish a three-bedroom apartment with beds, couches, tables, chairs, television, kitchenware, curtains and even art. This group of willing hearts transformed an apartment in Manchester into a home for this family who previously had nothing.

The seed of an idea took root. Suzie quickly realized this could be the start of a community effort to help women and single-parent families jump-start their lives after a deep struggle. She could take her love of design and home staging, combined with the generosity of friends and neighbors, and together establish these women in new "homes." (Note, after working through restorative programs and reinventing their lives, many women often have very little to bring with them into their next chapter.) Programs in our area provide many opportunities to help those who are successfully ready to take the next steps in life, and their graduates benefit from the encouragement provided by a peaceful place to call home.

Over the ensuing years, Suzie continued these efforts — each time receiving abundant donations from town members and garnering a group of volunteers to help pull it all together. Initially, the group helped women from one local recovery house, but soon the word spread. We learned of more worthy programs with more women in need. Additionally, our donation supply grew and grew.

Three years ago, Suzie decided to ask her core volunteers to help formalize their efforts, and Bless This Home was born. We currently have a small board of six women who organize, outreach and fundraise. Teens from Bedford High School provide lots of muscle for us and build up their community service hours. And over 35 other volunteers from the community work tirelessly every month to make each apartment space feel like a home.

Since inception, we have helped 87 women and children literally move into the next chapter of their lives. We could share a "divine happenstance" story for every single move: a last-minute dryer donation, a friend stopping by with a toaster oven (just what we needed), having sports-themed sheets and décor for a young boy, etc. It is both effort and joy to work with each recipient.

• • •

At the end of the day, at Bless This Home, we want everyone we help to feel cared for, encouraged and loved. Each one of us has made mistakes and endured struggles in our lives. No one is perfect. No life is without challenge. As a faith-based nonprofit, we truly believe the Bible's words in Ephesians 2:10, "For we are God's handiwork, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance for us to do." We feel fortunate we have an opportunity to serve others in our community in a way that utilizes our talents and abilities and meets their very practical needs at the same time. In the end, we are ALL blessed.

Our goal is to create functional, pleasing, and welcoming living spaces to establish women in their new homes with both dignity and pride. We are always in need of muscle and moving support. We welcome anyone who wants to offer their time and talents on prep and move days. We also have a small fund that supports essential purchases which go beyond our physical donations: new beds or occasional moving expenses when we are short volunteers.

To donate or learn more, go to www.blessthishome.org. You can also email us at info@blessthishome.org. Please see our wish list or designate us as your charity when you shop at smile.amazon.com.

From a mother after she arrived at her one-room space in a rooming house:

"I am crying tears of joy. I was in absolute shock when I walked in. Absolute amazement! This is the most beautiful room I have ever had. I can't even believe it. Somehow you all fit everything we could need in this room. I am so shocked by so many little details. I could go on and on. I can not thank you all enough! I feel so loved by you all and God. Thank you."

Would you like to nominate someone/some organization in the town to be featured? Reach out to us at **bedfordlivingnh@gmail.com**.

Dining area

Decorated breakfast nook

Foyer

Kids' play area

Bedroom

meet your neighbors:

the rankins FAMILY

Written by Resident **Suzie Rankins**

Photography By: **Courtney MacLaren Photography www.courtneymaclaren.com**

If you have any ideas for future features, please email us at bedfordlivingnh@gmail.com.

Have you ever had something weigh on your heart, and you knew you wanted to take action but didn't know when or how? That was me 20 years ago when a small seed of compassion for struggling women was planted deep in my being.

It all began after graduate school, when I was working as Dean of Students at Newton Country Day School of the Sacred Heart. Many of the students volunteered at Rosie's Place, a women's shelter in Boston. This establishment offered job training and housing placement for homeless women and did an excellent job preparing women for life beyond the shelter and finding them that new apartment, but then what? Once they moved, they had nothing ... no bed, no table, no chair to sit on or dishes to eat with. How could they feel settled or even feel like they could possibly get ahead? They were literally in an empty apartment! I knew someday I wanted to help fix this problem, and God kept it on my heart to do so.

Hi! I am Suzie Rankins, and I have lived in Bedford, NH, for 11 years. My husband, Kevin, is an emergency-room physician at Elliot Hospital. In my early career, I was a math professor and tutor. I have spent the last 17 years focused on raising our three children: Caroline, Ryan, and Lily. Caroline is heading to college next year to study animal science with hopes of becoming a veterinarian. Ryan, a high-school freshman, is enjoying sports and doing well in his academic studies. Lily is a joyful fifth-grader, dancing her way through life. We also care for my 84-year-old mother with dementia, who is lovingly known as "Nonny." She became a local celebrity last winter when her love for Ryan's basketball team and their love for her was featured on WMUR. She lived with us for three years and is now at Arbors of Bedford. Our family has been blessed in so many ways – a strong marriage, three busy children, good friends, and a community full of opportunity for fun and service to others. We attend Bethany Covenant Church, and our Christian faith is important in our everyday lives. We raise our children with the foundation of loving, caring and having compassion for both neighbor and stranger, always emphasizing that great privilege brings great responsibility. Community service has always been important to us, and we feel strongly about treating others with dignity, no matter their situation.

Now, back to the seed... Eight years ago, a social worker at Elliot Hospital asked if we could help obtain beds and a few essentials for a homeless family. It was a young mother with four children. Within two weeks, by reaching out to friends in the Bedford area, we were able to fully furnish the three-bedroom apartment with beds, couches, tables, chairs, television, kitchenware, curtains and even art. We transformed an apartment in Manchester into a home for this family that previously had nothing. At this point, I began to realize the idea planted so long ago in my heart could become a reality within this community.

Since that initial family, we helped two to three women each year. I have brought my love of interior design, combined with the generosity of friends and neighbors, and together we have helped establish these women in new "homes." Initially, we stored most of the donated furniture in our own home. Over time, the amount of goods exceeded our space, and a storage area was donated by Kyle Wallace, a friend and fellow Bedford resident. In the past year, with God's initial seed and the help of my fellow board members, we formalized this endeavor and founded the nonprofit organization called Bless This Home. Our ministry currently serves graduates from local rehab programs like New Life Home for Women and Children and Real Life Giving. With continued support, we hope to increase the number of women we serve and eventually expand outside the Manchester area. We are always accepting donations (household items and/or money), and we welcome anyone interested in the hands-on work of setting up a household. To get involved or follow the journey, you can find us on Facebook at Bless This Home.

Suzie and Kevin would like to thank the countless individuals in this community who have reached out to one or both of them about the current pandemic. The outpouring of well wishes and gratitude for Kevin being on the frontline of this crisis, and prayers of protection over him and the whole family during this time, has truly touched their hearts. Thank you, Bedford! Stay safe.

THANK YOU

Doctors Pharmacists First Responders
Truck & Delivery Drivers Police
Restaurant Workers Volunteers
Grocery Employees
Firefighters Nurses
Gas Station Employees
Hospital Staff
Scientists
EMTs

From all of us here at

Paul A. Pouliot & Associates
Ameriprise Private Wealth Advisory Practice

Thank you from the bottom of our hearts.

603.296.0030 | 116 S. RIVER RD. | BEDFORD, NH

Paul A. Pouliot & Associates, a private wealth advisory practice of Ameriprise Financial Services, Inc. The Compass is a trademark of Ameriprise Financial, Inc. Ameriprise Financial Services, Inc., Member FINRA and SIPC. © 2020 Ameriprise Financial, Inc. All rights reserved.